

By Stephen David

After the BJP won 19 seats in the state and became the largest contributor to the party's Lok Sabha kitty, Karnataka has replaced Gujarat as the BJP's show-piece state. In the days since, the ruling party in Karnataka—the first and only full-fledged BJP Government in power in south India—has embarked boldly on the party's Hindutva agenda without being weighed down by the compulsions of coalition allies, as happened in the shortlived first BJP government in November 2007.

For the record, the 34-member ministry has a token Muslim and a social scientist, but none from the Christian community. Even as communal riots racked Kyathamara-nahalli in Mysore district last week, state Home Minister V.S. Acharya, Law and Parliamentary Affairs Minister Suresh Kumar and Animal Husbandry Minister Revunaik Belamagi brainstormed to enact a law to ban cow slaughter to be passed in the Assembly. Acharya, who was part of the Jan Sangh-run municipal body in Udupi in the Mangalore coastal belt in 1968, said the current Prevention of Cow Slaughter and Cattle Protection Act of 1964 would be redrafted and given more teeth.

If this move—aimed at beef-eating minority communities—was not enough, Law Minister Kumar has already expressed his concern over the “conversion of Hindus to Christianity” while indicating the introduction of an anti-conversion law. The Karnataka Government will be the first south Indian state to endorse this anti-conversion law after Tamil Nadu hastily withdrew it. Kumar would like to study how former Tamil Nadu chief minister Jayalalithaa pulled it back after the Christian and Muslim communities raised a furore.

Apart from the two issues that are close to the Sangh Parivar and Hindu outfits, Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa gave a liberal Rs 100-crore grant in the March 2009 budget to some Hindu mutts in the state.



Moving to the RIGHT

The BJP Government flexes its muscles and embarks on a Hindutva agenda with plans of pro-Hindu Bills

“That is how secular our chief minister is in taking the concept of *akhanda* Hindu rashtra,” says Congress leader D.K. Shivakumar, who will debate the Cow Protection Bill in the Assembly. “Inter-faith harmony is the need of the hour and there should be no overt or covert attempt to push the RSS and BJP agenda in the state,” he says.

The Hindu-Muslim group clash in Kyathamara-nahalli had bobbed its head in April and was renewed last week over several reasons including

the sight of a very provocative object at a mosque. In a day of blood-letting, three people were knifed to death while a BJP youth wing chief in Mysore, assaulted by miscreants, battled for life in a hospital. Former Union law minister Hans Raj Bhardwaj, who was sworn in as Karnataka’s governor on June 29, said that communal harmony in the state would be his top priority. It was almost a premonition of things to come because the three killings occurred a few days after